

Pedestrian Advisory Committee Meeting Minutes

March 11, 2024 7 p.m. Remote via Zoom

Members Present: David Trevvett (chair), Anita Johnson, Marissa Vogt, Carey Radebaugh, Jesse Hefter

Members absent: Janice Morris; (one position is currently vacant)

Others Present: Shonali Guadino (Transportation Board Liaison), Fran Perler, Marion Freedman-Gurspan, Karen Weaver

1. Public Comment Period for Issues Not on the Agenda

There was no public comment.

2. Approval of Meeting Minutes from the February 12, 2024 meeting

There were several corrections to the minutes:

- Trevvett had mistakenly recorded a person as being present who was not actually there – it was just a fluke of zoom participant labeling. He will remove this erroneous entry.
- Hefter pointed out that we don't know who will inhabit the units in the Hancock Village expansion, so we can't be sure that this will lead to more high school students. Trevvett agreed to modify the wording accordingly.
- Hefter also suggested removing the word "supposedly" regarding the presence of a Lee Street bike lane. Trevvett agreed to make that change.

Subject to Trevvett making the above corrections, the minutes were approved 5-0 by roll call vote of the 5 members present.

3. Red-Light Camera Enforcement- Discussion of Draft Memo to Transportation Board

Trevvett reviewed the key points made in the draft memo, which essentially modifies this Committee's support of automated camera enforcement to acknowledge that there are real concerns about privacy and potential bias, based on the way in which such facilities have reportedly been implemented in other municipalities.

Radebaugh said he did not think our pedestrian advocacy committee should be on record as effectively saying that we would not support automated camera enforcement unless these conditions were met. Are we being balanced enough here? Separately, he was not as concerned about cameras being on all the time, but he understands why some are bothered by it.

Vogt shared Radebaugh's concerns. While she did not know all the details about ticketing etc., she felt that the committee clearly understands the need for more enforcement. In keeping with Vision Zero discussions, we need to be designing the roads in a way that minimizes the likelihood of crashes. She reminded committee members of the comment that she had made half-jokingly at the previous meeting – it's not really necessary to have cameras that are working, but just the existence of cameras and signs advertising them to change driver behavior.

Johnson asked if we have data about cars running red lights and hurting pedestrians. Trevvett observed that there's no data collection in Brookline or anywhere else on close calls, and close calls are a danger signal that crashes are likely. He observed that the police are more likely to have data on a car running a red light that crashes into another car from the cross street, potentially causing serious damage and injury on the driver's side of that other car.

Radebaugh agreed with Trevvett's observation that pedestrians have been trained over the years to look out for cars and to yield to them even when the pedestrians have the right of way, but he's concerned that young kids don't have as much training and may not be as careful, so are at greater risk. He agreed with taking more time with this memo, coming back to it at our next meeting, softening our recommendations, and acknowledging that any proposal to implement red-light enforcement would generate a lot of discussion in Town, so it doesn't have to fall on us to highlight all those issues. Our job is to be pro-pedestrian.

Freedman-Gurspan asked whether red-light cameras would also capture bicycles running red lights – she felt that this happens even more frequently than cars running red lights, and results in many more close calls.

Hefter also wondered about the frequency of crashes that result from cars running red lights, maybe over a 10-year period. He suggested that a distracted driver missing a red light is like a distracted pedestrian focusing on their cell phone. Trevvett warned against false equivalences, saying that the vehicle driver is driving a lethal machine, a type that can and does kill people, while the pedestrian is putting themselves at risk but is not likely to damage vehicles or others.

4. Pedestrian Impact of Potential Bike Lane Configurations on Beacon Street

Trevvett explained that DPW is considering a surface treatment to Beacon Street similar to what they did on Washington Street (a “bonded wearing course”?). In each case a major reconstruction is planned in the future, but the deteriorating road surface needs some attention now. They are thinking about taking advantage of the planned new surface to repaint the roadway for bicycle lanes, and considering parking-protected bike lanes as was done on Beacon St at St Mary's. They have asked us for our reactions to that idea.

Trevvett showed a diagram of the parking-protected bike lanes implemented at St Mary's. Hefter observed that this arrangement increases the distance between pedestrians on the sidewalks and the vehicle travel lanes, which is good for pedestrian safety. Trevvett noted that as soon as people who've arrived by car get out of their cars, they become pedestrians, so we need to think about their safety as well.

Several people liked the curb extension at the mid-block crosswalk to the St Mary's T station, which shortens the crossing distance and creates a curve in the bike lane that might slow bicyclists down. They noted that a pure straightaway bicycle lane might encourage bicyclists to speed through even faster. There was agreement that this design is safer for bicyclists, but drivers and passengers of cars parked there have active travel lanes on both sides of them when they get out, which feels less safe.

Freedman-Gurspan said that, as a senior driver, she's typically taking people who have walkers and wheelchairs, so having enough space for such passengers to get out of the car is important. Even a three-foot buffer is not enough for a wheelchair that must be turned towards the car in order for the passenger who needs it to move from car to wheelchair. When such individuals get out of a car, it's a slow process. The mobility devices are usually in the trunk, must be taken out and set up. And if someone vulnerable gets hit by a bike, it's a more serious situation. Bicyclists are unlikely, when faced with such a situation, to move onto the sidewalk and walk their bike past the slowly-emerging senior or handicapped person. Another issue she faces as a driver coming down St Mary's street and making a right turn onto Beacon is that there's often a delivery van or other large vehicle in the first parking space to the left, making it very difficult to see oncoming (outbound) traffic. Finally, it can be hard to park on those spots which lack a curb or other hard boundary, and in her older car that lacks modern backup and side cameras, she worries about parking too far in and potentially harming bicyclists.

Perler did not think that the bumpout curve would really slow bicyclists down. Separately she noted that the trend of “skinnying” the vehicle travel lanes means that there isn't much room for a car in

the travel lane to get out of your way if you're getting out of your car on the driver's side. On other streets where parking lanes have been narrowed, parked cars often extend into the travel lanes. This creates a dangerous situation. Another danger is with young children getting out of the car – they will tend to run to the sidewalk, it's hard for them to wait in the buffer zone.

Trevvett observed that almost any roadway configuration is probably dangerous for someone, so we need to think about how we can achieve a balance. Maybe this particular configuration is great for some pedestrians and not good for others. Perhaps we should articulate those different groups and explain why or why not the design would work for them.

Johnson felt that this parking-protected bike lane configuration actually made bicyclists more vulnerable at corners from turning vehicles, because the parked cars block drivers' views of the bikes. They can also block views of pedestrians about to cross the side streets. Trevvett responded by noting the "daylighting" policy proposed by this committee and adopted by the Transportation Board. That policy prohibits parking within 20 feet on the approach side to a crosswalk. If that policy is followed, then the concern about visibility should be sufficiently addressed.

Hefter wondered if there is any data on crashes or other incidents at the St Mary's location during the time since the protected bike lanes there were installed. Trevvett agreed that we should attempt to find out.

Freedman-Gurspan said she had talked with a police officer at the polls on election day and learned that no data at all is collected on pedestrians injured by bikes. Even if someone calls in to report the incident, the police don't retain the data. She also thought that bicycle traffic tends to be heavy just at certain hours of the day, such as morning and evening rush hours, whereas at other times one hardly sees any bikes at all. It would certainly be helpful if the town kept track of near misses of all kinds.

Trevvett also noted that it could be good for seniors who have the concerns being expressed tonight by Perler and Freedman-Gurspan would attend the Bicycle Advisory Committee (BAC) meetings, since it's really that committee that strongly advocates for better bicycle accommodations such as the separated lanes we're discussing tonight.

Regarding the concerns expressed about narrow travel and parking lanes, Trevvett cited evidence that the combination of parked cars and narrow travel lanes helps slow traffic down, where as wider lanes encourage speeding.

Hefter wondered about having a conversation or joint meeting with the BAC, so that we can hear what they have to say about this design. Trevvett reported that Mitch Heineman, BAC chair, had just floated the idea of a joint meeting. It's probably not possible for our April 8 meeting, but he can check with Heineman. Perhaps there could be a short joint meeting devoted to this particular issue.

Vogt indicated that our committee's priority should be to slow everything down, anything that could run into a pedestrian – car, bicycle, other devices. This design is certainly safest for bicycles, but bicyclists need to be ready to brake or maneuver out of the way if necessary.

Trevvett offered to assemble a list of considerations, based on tonight's discussion, that we could discuss on April 8 and that might feed into a memo that we would want to submit.

5. Brief Review of Walk Signal Timing Basics

Trevvett noted that he had distributed a 7-page "walk signal tutorial" with tonight's meeting materials. He hoped that everyone had been able to read it, and he did not plan to cover all of that tonight. Mainly, we want everyone to understand some basic points about how walk signals work in preparation for our planned April 8 discussion with DPW Transportation.

He then went over the following key points:

- Every intersection has its own, separate control cabinet for the signals at that intersection. There is no central “control room.”
- Within the overall traffic signal cycle at any intersection, there is a specific slot for each configuration that may occur. So if you’re at an intersection where you need to press the button in order to receive a walk signal, the walk signal usually does not come on as soon as you press the button. Rather the button notifies the control cabinet that a walk signal has been requested, and when the control cabinet gets to the “walk signal” slot in the overall traffic signal cycle, it turns the walk signal on.
- Every walk signal sequence has three sub-parts: first the walking person icon (or the word “walk”), which is required to be at least 7 seconds at most intersections; then the flashing red hand or count-down display, which is supposed to provide enough time for pedestrians who’ve just entered the intersection to complete crossing the street (the “clearance” interval); then a short buffer of at least 3 seconds from the point when the steady red hand or “Don’t Walk” words come on until the cross traffic receives a green light.
- The minimum duration of an entire walk signal sequence is *longer* than the minimum length of a vehicle green & yellow light sequence. The latter can be as short as 5-7 seconds, because cars simply move faster. Pedestrians need more time to cross the street. This complicates signal programming and trade-offs.
- Using the St Paul / Beacon intersection as an example, the slot in the signal cycle when outbound Beacon traffic has both a green light AND a left turn signal is *different* from the slot in the cycle when both outbound and inbound traffic have green lights together. Back in 2019 he had learned from Transportation that a walk signal can only be tied to one of those. Given the Town’s current control cabinets, the walk signal can’t overlap two slots in the cycle, even though it would be safe for pedestrians to be walking during both.

Trevvett encouraged everyone to read the tutorial document before the April 8 meeting.

6. Any Additions to Walk Signal Questions for DPW Transportation Staff?

There were no questions or suggestions for additions to the list of questions.

7. Brief Updates

Washington Street Design and Design Review Committee (DRC)

There hasn’t been another meeting of the DRC since November, but the project has exploded into public view. There’s been substantial expression of concerns on the Town Meeting Members (TMM) email list, there was a lot of public comment at recent Transportation Board and Select Board meetings, including from business owners, and even an article in Brookline.News. The major complaint has been the dramatic reduction in parking spaces in the trial design that was presented at the November DRC meeting. That design was developed to provide buffered bike lanes in both directions between Beacon Street and at least Cypress. It’s not easy to provide both parking and protected bike lanes, it involves difficult trade-offs.

Trevvett indicated that he and a couple of other DRC members have been talking with each other about ways in which the design might be modified to provide a better balance.

Committee Vacancy

Trevvett said he had written to Transportation staff about publicizing our Committee's current vacancy, but had not heard back yet. He will follow up now that Amy Ingles is back in the office.

Annual Report

He had not yet heard anything further about the previously-reported notice that boards, commissions, and committees all needed to file annual reports.

Communication with Police Department

We still do not have a good channel of communication with the Police Department. Recently Transportation Engineer Sam Downes mentioned that he knows Sergeant Robert Collins, the designated Police liaison to our Committee, and will talk with him. His understanding is that Collins often (mostly?) works an evening shift, which makes it not possible for him to attend our meetings. Trevvett mentioned to Downes our Committee's ideas of perhaps having a daytime meeting at the Public Safety Office to make it easier for someone from the Police Department to sit down with us for a good conversation.

8. Committee Housekeeping

Our next meeting will be on Monday, April 8, 2024 at 7pm via Zoom

Earlier there had been the possibility that there might be a Town Meeting session on Monday June 10, which would prevent our Committee from meeting on its regular date that month. Luckily the Warrant for this Town Meeting is substantially shorter than most recent Town Meetings, so should wrap up well before June 10.

9. New Business

Trevvett observed that chairing this Committee is a substantial effort, something like a full-time job. He is trying to think of ways to reduce or at least share the workload, and asked Committee members to think about this. One idea he mentioned was perhaps meeting less frequently, maybe every other month instead of every month.

Radebaugh suggested that, especially as the weather turns nicer, we could arrange to walk around and look at particular areas. It could help to be talking about issues as we're standing in front of them, and it could be fun & enjoyable as well. Trevvett recalled that in the early years of this committee, we had done that a couple of times – along Longwood Ave, and in a large circle around Coolidge Corner. He noted that if it includes a quorum of Committee members, it must be a publicly posted meeting, and members of the public are free to come along for the walk. He agreed that it could be good to have such a meeting this year. Different people tend to notice different things, so it can be good to do it as a group.

Anita observed that she's looking at the paths of Brookline, most of which are steep and have stairs. She asked that people let her know about any problems they see on the paths – e.g., areas needing repair or reconstruction – and she will assemble them to submit to the Town. Similarly let her know of any places where a new bench might be needed. Several members commented on the very helpful guidebook for the paths that Linda Olsen Pehlke had written years ago, and which is evidently still available.

The meeting was adjourned at approximately 8:30 pm.

Minutes prepared by David Trevvett